

THE MASTER'S SOP STARTER KIT



How to write an SOP that
makes grad schools say...
"YES!"



THE MASTER'S SOP FORMULA

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The SOP Starter Kit

Imagine how it'll feel to submit your SOP and know—just know—it's exactly what grad school faculty *want to read*.

Not only will you prove you're the exact kind of student they *always admit*, but you'll probably hit "submit" with far less stress than you thought possible.

No matter your background, GPA, or professional experience...you'll sit back happy, proud, and certain that professors at your target schools will see you as their ideal student. That, in fact, they'll *want to admit you*.

Yes, you can engineer that result. Why? Because...

The SOP is a Test

And that test contains 4 questions.

And as long as you answer those 4 questions correctly somewhere in your SOP, admissions readers will know you're...

- **Intelligent,**
- **Self-disciplined, and...**
- ***Qualified***

Let's answer these questions one-by-one. When you're done, you'll truly be ready to engineer admission to your dream grad school.

QUESTION

01

What problems do you want to solve?

Maybe you're applying because you want a better, higher-paying job. Or perhaps you're a research-focused student dreaming of a PhD.

In either case, the best applicants are ALWAYS those who frame their academic goals around *the focus-problems* they want to learn to solve.

If you're professional-track (e.g. MS Finance, MSW, MHA, MSCS), these focus-problems will presumably be the sticky issues that someone will pay you to solve in the future.

If you're research-track (e.g. rotation-based MS Biochemistry), these will be the research questions—or current gaps in the literature—you hope to investigate.

Bad Example (No Focus Problems)

"My ambition to continue learning new skills, exploring the scientific method, and learning more about the molecular world has resulted in my decision to pursue a degree in Biomedical Sciences."

Good Examples

1. "I want to apply my work towards answering scientific questions, such as 'How is *Giardia canis* developing resistance to metronidazole?' or 'How can we effectively control helminthiasis without anthelmintic use?'"
2. "I hope to contribute to my country's education system by researching cognitive frameworks that promote positive thoughts, beliefs, and actions, and ultimately help 'troubled students' break free from self-limiting labels."
3. "Today, I hope to expand upon my experiences by studying and conducting research at the intersection of finance and machine learning, with a focus on generative adversarial networks and ML models to synthesize alternative financial data. Specifically, I hope to understand how the ML models traditionally used for institutional high-frequency trading (e.g. Markov Decision Models within Reinforcement Learning) can be adopted into accessible personal-finance tools for retail investors."

What problems do you want to solve?

Write 1-2 sentences describing the focus-problems that interest you most:

QUESTION

02

Why am I interested in solving these problems?

The best applicants have a story that makes them memorable in the admissions pool. It isn't an autobiography. It isn't a life story. Instead, it's a mature, factual account of how they discovered their focus-problems.

I get it though—some applicants don't have an amazing lightbulb moment where they were inspired to change the world. Instead, they just want a better job.

That's okay! You can say that!

As long as you're honest and thorough, you can still write an amazing SOP that makes you sound like a perfect MS or MA candidate, one who has *earned* and *deserves* this new career.

Bad Example (No Real Explanation)

"Throughout my life, I have always been interested in helping others. To pursue this goal, I chose to major in Psychology at Gotham University. Today, I apply for a Master's in Social Work to further prepare to achieve my lifelong goal."

Good Examples

1. "As a Senior Associate in WayneHealth's research-reagent manufacturing division, I often partake in initiatives to improve product-maintenance and launch-process efficiencies. Over time, however, I have witnessed these initiatives shift toward technological innovation: for example, onboarding cloud solutions for data storage, or automation via scripting and web-scraping. With my own non-technical background in pharmaceuticals, I have often felt restricted in my ability to lead these changes. Yet, this is precisely why I am applying to the MSIT program at Gotham University today..."

2. "As an intern at Wayne Semiconductor Corp., I helped optimize operational expenditures, saving over \$200 thousand annually toward production of polycrystalline silicon for solar applications. During that time, I witnessed massive improvements to polysilicon production processes, and expected similar improvements for the Silicon Photovoltaic (PV) cells produced from this polysilicon. But, these improvements have not yet been realized. Raised in the scorching climate of Nigeria, and having seen electricity as a luxury, I am all too aware of the need to understand how we can more efficiently harness solar energy."

Why are you interested in solving these problems?

Write 2-3 sentences explaining how or why you've chosen your focus problems:

QUESTION

03

How will this master's program help me learn to solve these problems?

If you don't answer this question in your SOP, there's a ***near zero chance*** that anyone will take you seriously as an applicant.

It's that important.

All A+ applicants methodically explain how each school to will help them achieve their specific intellectual and career goals.

Bad Example (No Specific Detail)

"I believe the cutting-edge laboratories and world-class faculty at Gotham University will be the pivotal next step in helping me achieve my goal of saving the world with AI."

Good Examples

1. "Through courses like *Intro to Computer Vision* (MSAI 329) and *Deep Learning* (MSAI 407), I hope to gain a comprehensive understanding of computer vision, its current limitations, and how it can be advanced. This will provide the foundation I need to contribute to the development of accurate and robust machine-learning models for image classification in

medical diagnosis. Furthermore, *Innovate: Medical* (MBUS 450) will guide me toward creating business plans that turn medical innovations into achievable ventures, while *Financial Foundations for Entrepreneurs* (MBUS 382) will provide hands-on experience with the financial accounting necessary for startup businesses — a crucial aspect of my long-term goals.”

2. “I am particularly inspired by Professor Jonathan Crane’s research and teaching. His work focuses on the effects of media on human development and civic behavior, echoing my interest in how digital tools can sometimes obfuscate traditional visual cultures for the general public. Professor Crane will be an ideal mentor as I hopefully continue to document site-specific architectures, sculptures, and murals in Diyarbakir. I am similarly inspired by Professor Pamela Isley, whose research focuses on the role of close observation in learning, and learning in and through the arts.”

How will this program help you learn to solve these problems?

Write a paragraph (or bullet points) highlighting key program features:

QUESTION

04

What convincing proof do I have that I'm 100% ready to study these problems as a graduate student?

The final piece in your SOP puzzle is proving to the admissions committee that you're "qualified." Luckily, that'll be easy, right? Even if you've had difficulties in the past, you know how hard you've worked. You know you're capable of succeeding in grad school. Now, we just have to make sure your reader knows too.

When answering this question, think of it as a highlight reel. It's NOT an expansive and detailed list of everything you've ever accomplished. That's what the resume/CV is for! Instead, this is your *Greatest Hits* album—a description of your most unique accomplishments. These accolades prove that ***you're prepared*** to study the applications or problems you listed in Question #1.

What Should I Include?

Feel free to pick and choose from any of the items below. Discard the ones that aren't relevant for you and focus on the ones that really make you shine.

GRADE POINT AVERAGE

What was your undergrad GPA? Your major GPA? Were they impressive? Good, let's mention those. They show that you worked harder than your peers.

AWARDS AND HONORS

Did you receive any official awards which prove how disciplined a student you are? Phi Beta Kappa? The Stark University Leadership Award in Genomics?

GRAD-LEVEL COURSEWORK

Did you take any relevant graduate classes? Did you make As? Awesome. DEFINITELY mention that.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCES

Did you do any research or independent studies relevant to your academic goal? Beautiful - you'll want a 1-2 sentence description.

INTERNSHIPS / CAREER EXPERIENCES

Have you had any relevant internships or job responsibilities which were related to your goal? How were they different than the experiences other applicants have? How have they prepared you for this next step?

TECHNICAL / LABORATORY SKILLS

Are you a full-stack developer? A wizard with Python, Ruby, and Shell? Are you experienced with cell and tissue cultures? Electrophoresis? Or, perhaps you speak a foreign language that will help you in your research?

What proof do you have that you're 100% ready to pursue these problems as a grad student?

Outline 1-3 paragraphs that explain your “Greatest Hits”:

This image shows a full page of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page, providing a template for handwriting practice or general writing. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the page.

Congratulations!



Now, you're on your way. At this point, you've defined:

1. Your focus-problems
2. Why you care about them
3. How this school will help you study them
4. And why you're qualified to study them

That, my friend, is what we call an argument. Now, outlining your SOP will be easy.

Of course, I have strong feelings about *how* to structure that outline (which you can [see here](#)). But really, as long as you answer all four questions somewhere in the essay, you'll be WAY ahead of the game.

The fact is, *thoughtfully* answering these questions is the single most powerful way I've found to persuade admissions committees that you're 100% prepared to be a *successful* grad student.

It's worked for hundreds and hundreds of applicants, in virtually every academic field, at every "brand name" university you can think of.

Now it's your turn.

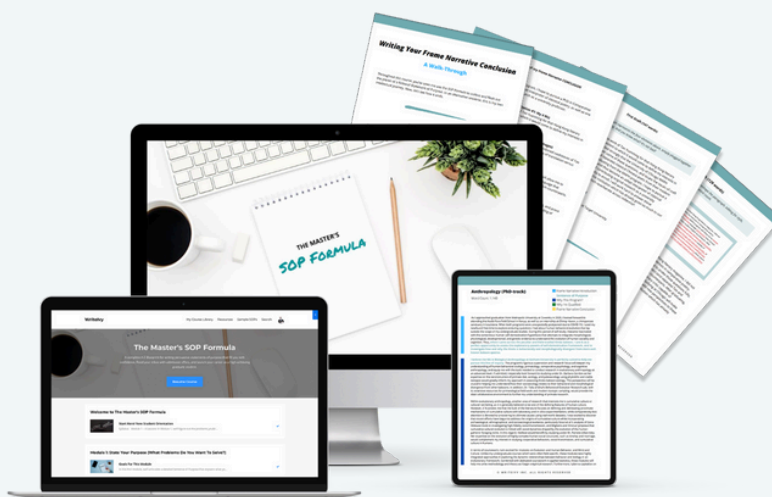
In the next few days, I'll send you some examples of how other students answered the 4 questions in their SOPs. You'll see what it takes to move from feeling overwhelmed and frustrated with your applications, to becoming an intellectual dynamo who grad schools WANT to admit!

Jordan

Want to give yourself the best possible chance of admission?

The 4 questions are always the right place to start. But you know what's even better? Learning exactly **how** and **where** to answer those questions in your SOP...without ever second-guessing yourself. If you want to submit a statement of purpose that's **bulletproof**, check out...

THE MASTER'S SOP FORMULA



ONLINE COURSE: Learn the proven application strategy that's helped hundreds of students get accepted to 5-10 top master's programs...even if you're not a "writer," have a low GPA, or just feel nervous and confused.

(This is the exact system one self-described "average student" used to write his SOP in just two weeks...and earn **admission to 13 competitive schools**. I'll breakdown his essay for you inside, explain why it worked, and show you how to do the same!)

TELL ME MORE!